

THE GLOBAL ECONOMY

AN INCREASING DIVIDE BETWEEN RICH AND POOR

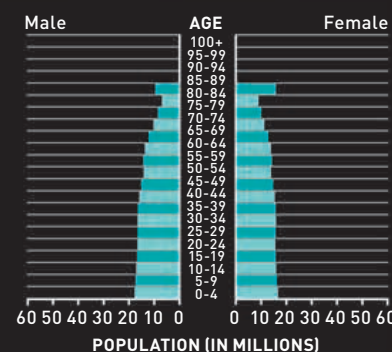
The world is richer than ever, strengthened by international alliances and technology, but there is still widespread poverty. Wars continue to be fought, and even developed nations can be devastated by natural disasters.

There are currently almost 7 billion people living on the planet, three times the population of 1900. The fate of each person depends on where they live, and the distribution of the world's wealth has changed little since World War II. Many high-income countries are in the northern hemisphere, with the world's poorest in sub-Saharan Africa. The six wealthiest countries account for more than half the world's Gross Domestic Product (GDP)—the value of all the goods and services a country produces—while over half the world's population live on less than \$2.50 a day.

The countries of Western Europe and North America have well-established business sectors, with multinational corporations selling products globally. The nations of Africa and Central America have a smaller range of industries, and many depend on trading a single commodity. But this is slowly changing, and the economies of countries such as Mexico, Brazil, and India are growing rapidly.

THE US

Although the US is the wealthiest country in the world, it is home to only 5.2 percent of the world's population. Forty-one percent of the world's millionaires live in the US, but it also has the highest level of total household debt.



NORTH AMERICA

ATLANTIC OCEAN

Interdependent world

The economies of the world are based on a vast range of industries, and populations range from 800 (Vatican City) to over a billion (India and China). No countries are fully self-supporting, however, and they all depend on trade with other countries to meet their needs fully.

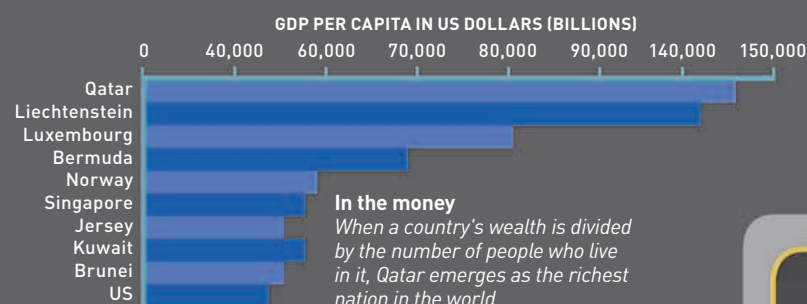
PACIFIC OCEAN

SOUTH AMERICA

ATLANTIC OCEAN

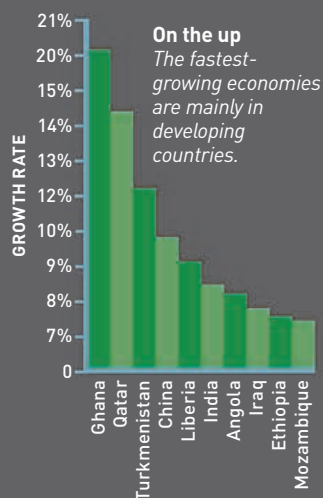
BRAZIL

Brazil has the largest economy in South America, and the ninth largest in the world. Well-established agriculture, mining, and service sectors have helped create a healthy economy, and Brazil is also rich in natural resources. Huge gaps remain between rich and poor, however.



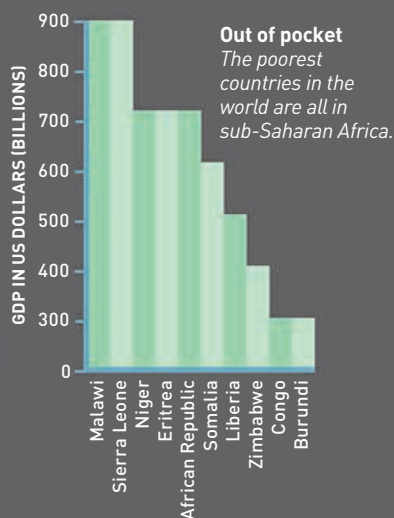
In the money

When a country's wealth is divided by the number of people who live in it, Qatar emerges as the richest nation in the world.



On the up

The fastest-growing economies are mainly in developing countries.



Out of pocket

The poorest countries in the world are all in sub-Saharan Africa.